

D485

Cloud Security

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	_____	

Items

1.

A startup runs its app on virtual machines rented from a public cloud (IaaS). The provider operates data centers in 30 regions. Who is responsible for patching the guest operating system?

- A. The provider.
- B. The startup.
- C. No one; IaaS operating systems always patch themselves.
- D. The provider, because of its global scale.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

In a SaaS model, what is the customer still responsible for?

- A. Nothing at all.
- B. Patching the application code.
- C. Its data, user accounts, and access and sharing settings.
- D. Physical data center security.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3.

A development team wants to deploy code without managing servers or operating systems, with the runtime and database managed by the provider. The team has eight developers in two countries. Which service model fits?

- A. PaaS
- B. IaaS
- C. SaaS
- D. A private cloud.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A company uses a hosted email and office suite through a browser and configures only users and settings. Which service model is this?

- A.** IaaS
- B.** Hybrid
- C.** PaaS
- D.** SaaS

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5.

A hospital keeps patient records in its own data center but sends heavy analytics jobs to a public cloud at month-end. It also leases two colocation cages. Which deployment model is this?

- A.** Public cloud
- B.** Hybrid cloud
- C.** Private cloud
- D.** Community cloud

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6.

A developer uses the cloud account's root user, with a long-lived access key embedded in a CI pipeline. The pipeline deploys 20 times a day. What is the best fix?

- A.** Protect root with MFA and stop using it; give the pipeline a least-privilege role with short-lived credentials.
- B.** Create a new user with full admin rights for the pipeline.
- C.** Deploy less often.
- D.** Rotate the root access key monthly.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

An auditor finds a role whose permissions go far beyond what its workload uses. Which principle is violated?

- A.** None, since unused permissions can never cause harm.
- B.** Defense in depth.
- C.** Least privilege.
- D.** Separation of duties.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8.

A fintech must show it can cut off access to its encrypted cloud data on its own, without relying on the provider. The data sits in object storage in two regions. Which approach fits?

- A.** Store the key in the same bucket as the data.
- B.** Use TLS for all connections.
- C.** Rely on the provider's default managed encryption.
- D.** Encrypt with customer-managed keys that the fintech can disable or revoke.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9.

After several virtual machines are deleted without warning, investigators find no record of who called the delete API. The company has three cloud accounts. Which control was missing?

- A.** Guest OS logging on each VM.
- B.** CPU usage monitoring.
- C.** Control-plane audit logging in every account, sent to a protected central log store.
- D.** Merging into a single account.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10.

A marketing team stored customer lists in an object storage bucket set to public-read for convenience. The bucket name is random-looking and hard to guess. What is the most effective control?

- A.** Turn on versioning.
- B.** Turn on encryption at rest.
- C.** Keep it; the random name is protection enough.
- D.** Block public access at the account level and use posture monitoring to catch future misconfigurations.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11.

A healthcare SaaS company hosts on a provider that holds a SOC 2 report and offers HIPAA-eligible services. The provider is publicly traded. Is the company compliant because of this?

- A.** It needs only its own SOC 2; the provider's report does not matter.
- B.** No; it must still sign a business associate agreement and configure its own access, encryption, and logging.
- C.** Yes; the provider's attestation covers everything.
- D.** Yes; public companies are fully audited.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A company must keep EU customer data inside the EU. Which cloud control addresses this?

- A.** Policies that restrict resources and backups to EU regions.
- B.** Requiring MFA for all users.
- C.** Choosing a provider headquartered in the EU.
- D.** Encrypting all data.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer B Concept 1

A startup runs its app on virtual machines rented from a public cloud (IaaS). ~~The provider operates data centers in 30 regions.~~ Who is responsible for patching the guest operating system?

Target word: responsibility for guest OS **Decides:** IaaS gives the customer the OS layer.

A	Inverted operation	The provider handles hardware and the hypervisor, not the guest OS.
B	Correct	In IaaS the customer manages the OS and everything above it.
C	Absolute language	Patching is the customer's job unless it sets up automation.
D	Camouflage	Region count does not change the model.

2. Answer C Concept 1 • transfer

In a SaaS model, what is the customer still responsible for?

Target word: reverse: model to customer duties **Decides:** Customer always owns data and access.

A	Absolute language	Data and identity are always the customer's.
B	Inverted operation	The SaaS provider maintains the application.
C	Correct	These stay with the customer in every model.
D	Confusion set	Always the provider's job.

3. Answer A Concept 2

A development team wants to deploy code without managing servers or operating systems, with the runtime and database managed by the provider. ~~The team has eight developers in two countries.~~ Which service model fits?

Target word: service model **Decides:** Customer manages only code and data.

A	Correct	The platform runs the runtime and middleware; the team brings code.
B	Adjacent category	They would still manage the OS.
C	Confusion set	SaaS is a finished app; there is no code to deploy.
D	Dropped element	That is a deployment model; it does not say what the team manages.

4. Answer D Concept 2 • transfer

A company uses a hosted email and office suite through a browser and configures only users and settings. Which service model is this?

Target word: reverse: usage to model **Decides:** A finished application is consumed.

A	Inverted operation	IaaS leaves the most to the customer.
B	Confusion set	A deployment model, not a service model.
C	Adjacent category	PaaS is for deploying your own code.
D	Correct	The provider runs the whole application.

5. Answer B Concept 3

A hospital keeps patient records in its own data center but sends heavy analytics jobs to a public cloud at month-end. ~~It also leases two colocation cages.~~ Which deployment model is this?

Target word: deployment model **Decides:** Private and public environments working together.

A	Dropped element	Ignores the private data center.
B	Correct	Combines private infrastructure with public cloud.
C	Adjacent category	Ignores the public-cloud workloads.
D	Confusion set	Shared by organizations with common needs; not this case.

6. Answer A Concept 4

A developer uses the cloud account's root user, with a long-lived access key embedded in a CI pipeline. ~~The pipeline deploys 20 times a day.~~ What is the best fix?

Target word: IAM fix **Decides:** Root credentials in automation.

A	Correct	Removes standing high-power keys from automation.
B	Dropped element	Drops least privilege.
C	Camouflage	Frequency is not the risk.
D	Adjacent category	Still uses root for daily work.

7. Answer C Concept 4 · transfer

An auditor finds a role whose permissions go far beyond what its workload uses. Which principle is violated?

Target word: name the principle **Decides:** Excess permissions.

A	Absolute language	Stolen credentials can use every permission granted.
B	Adjacent category	About layered controls.
C	Correct	Access should match what the task needs.
D	Confusion set	About splitting tasks between people.

8. Answer D Concept 5

A fintech must show it can cut off access to its encrypted cloud data on its own, without relying on the provider. ~~The data sits in object storage in two regions.~~ Which approach fits?

Target word: key control **Decides:** Independent control over decryption.

A	Inverted operation	Anyone who reaches the data also gets the key.
B	Confusion set	TLS protects data in transit, not at rest.
C	Adjacent category	The provider controls those keys.
D	Correct	Disabling the key makes the data unreadable.

9. Answer C Concept 6

After several virtual machines are deleted without warning, investigators find no record of who called the delete API. ~~The company has three cloud accounts.~~ Which control was missing?

Target word: missing control **Decides:** No API-level audit trail.

A	Adjacent category	The OS cannot see cloud API calls, and the VMs are gone.
B	Confusion set	Performance data does not show who did what.
C	Correct	Records who called which API and when.
D	Camouflage	Account count is not the gap.

10. Answer D Concept 7

A marketing team stored customer lists in an object storage bucket set to public-read for convenience. ~~The bucket name is random-looking and hard to guess.~~ What is the most effective control?

Target word: fix misconfiguration **Decides:** Public access is enabled.

A	Confusion set	Keeps old copies; does not restrict access.
B	Adjacent category	Public readers still get decrypted data.
C	Camouflage	Obscurity is not access control.
D	Correct	Removes exposure and keeps it from coming back.

11. Answer B Concept 8

A healthcare SaaS company hosts on a provider that holds a SOC 2 report and offers HIPAA-eligible services. ~~The provider is publicly traded.~~ Is the company compliant because of this?

Target word: inherited vs. owned compliance **Decides:** Attestations cover only the provider's side.

A	Inverted operation	Both sides' controls matter.
B	Correct	The customer's share of controls is its own to meet.
C	Absolute language	It covers the provider's controls only.
D	Camouflage	Financial audits are not HIPAA compliance.

12. Answer A Concept 8 • transfer

A company must keep EU customer data inside the EU. Which cloud control addresses this?

Target word: data residency control **Decides:** Location of storage and processing.

A	Correct	Keeps data where the requirement says.
B	Confusion set	About identity, not location.
C	Dropped element	Headquarters does not fix where data is stored.
D	Adjacent category	Protects content but does not control location.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owned.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	4	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	0	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	9	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	5	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	4	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	9	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	5	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	Shared responsibility	The provider secures the layers it runs; the customer secures everything above. In IaaS the customer owns the guest OS up; in every model the customer owns its data, identities, and access settings.	Assuming the provider patches or secures everything.	“Who is responsible for ...” with a named service model.
2	Service models	IaaS = rent virtual infrastructure; PaaS = deploy code on a managed platform; SaaS = use a finished application.	Calling a managed runtime IaaS or a hosted app PaaS.	What the customer still manages.
3	Deployment models	Public = shared provider infrastructure; private = one organization; hybrid = private plus public working together; community = shared by organizations with common needs.	Calling on-premises plus cloud bursting “public.”	Workloads split between an owned data center and a public cloud.
4	Cloud IAM	Lock down the root account with MFA and do not use it day to day; give workloads least-privilege roles with short-lived credentials.	Rotating a root key instead of retiring its use.	Root or admin credentials embedded in automation.
5	Encryption and key control	Customer-managed keys let the customer disable or revoke access independently of the provider; TLS protects data in transit, not at rest.	Relying on provider-managed defaults when independent control is required.	“Revoke access independently of the provider.”
6	Audit logging and monitoring	Enable control-plane (API) audit logs in every account and send them to a protected central store.	Relying on guest OS logs to see cloud API actions.	“No record of who called the API.”
7	Misconfiguration	Most cloud data exposure comes from misconfiguration; block public access by default and continuously check posture.	Trusting obscure names or encryption to protect public storage.	A bucket set to public for convenience.
8	Compliance in the cloud	Provider attestations cover the provider’s controls only; the customer must configure and govern its own part, including data residency.	Assuming a compliant provider makes the customer compliant.	Provider certifications cited as proof of the customer’s compliance.

Course scope (public description): Cloud Security prepares learners to design solutions for cloud-based platforms and operations that maintain data availability while protecting the confidentiality and integrity of information. Course topics include cloud service models, deployment methods, identity and access management (IAM) strategies, auditing and monitoring strategies, assessing and mitigating common cloud security threats, and managing compliance and regulation requirements. The course also offers hands-on experience deploying and assessing IAM controls in a cloud environment.